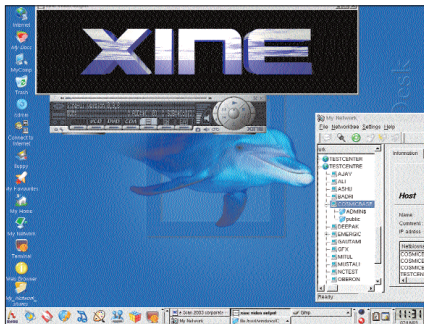




fied; instead of assigning partitions for individual directories, you can check the box labelled 'I want to use this as the main partition (/)'. Moreover, you can either use the remaining free space, or specify the the partition size in MB.

The install process is time consuming due to the installation of a whole lot of applications. Interestingly, this is the only distro that comes with 'Asia/Calcutta' as the default time zone.

After installation, the user is asked for basic configuration information, using KPersonaliser during the first login. ELX Power Desktop 2.0 has a very friendly desktop with simple Windows style icons, such as My Computer, My Network, etc.

Strangely, the minimum hard drive space mentioned was 1 GB, but the default install took up 3 GB of space.

ELX works well with KDE, but does not work properly with Gnome. The panel crashed during the first Gnome session, and we had to use the shortcut keys to start the X server; a novice user could not have done that. Also, the My Computer icon did not function under Gnome.

Accessing Windows shares is extreme-

ly easy. During installation, you are prompted to specify a workgroup name. Later, just click on the Network Neighbourhood icon to get a listing of all the machines on the network, and their network shares.

All applications are neatly categorised into six groups—Office, Internet, Multimedia, Graphics, Development tools, and Games. All these groups have icons (called Launchpads) on the task bar. Clicking on any one of these icons brings up a dialog box containing separate icons for the individual applications within that group. A button, to update all the applications in a particular group, is also provided. The Launchpad also acts as a front end to the apt-get package manager. Select 'Update all' from the Launchpad, to update all the packages, and their dependencies via ftp sites. For the root user (administrator), a couple of extra launchpads are provided. The system configuration Launchpad has a handy set of tools to make system configuration an easy affair.

Apart from some of these customised utilities, the rest of the tools are generally KDE-based utilities. For example, adding, or removing users can be done using the KDE User Manager (Kuser). Similarly, printer configuration uses the standard KDE Printer Manager. But what is commendable here is that a very simple way of accessing all the relevant tools is provided. Clicking on the My Computer icon on the desktop will bring up a window that has almost all the tools found

on a standard Windows computer including a Dial-up Account icon.

As can be seen from the comparison chart, ELX turned out to be a very surprising distro in many respects. Apart from using a very easy desktop, they have also developed some very simple but ingenious tools. The samba file sharing front end is a classic example. While the majority of distros used the Konqueror browser to access Windows shares, the separate tool provided by ELX is comfortable to use. Moreover, this distro is free for personal and educational use. The commercial licensing is also very reasonable.

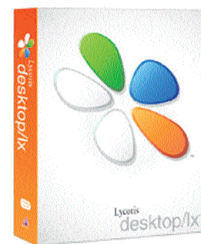
Lycoris Desktop/LX review: The problematic Windows look-alike

Lycoris has one of the most simple, and fastest installations of all the distros tested. However, even a small problem with hardware compatibility, such as an undetected mouse, could bring down the installation utility.

In terms of look and feel, Lycoris was the closest to the Windows desktop. It even has a default wallpaper that has a striking resemblance to the one that comes with Windows XP. A guided tour starts up during first boot, which walks you through all the features of the Lycoris desktop. This is very helpful to the first-time Linux user migrating from Windows to Linux.

Lycoris had the worst hardware support amongst all the distros. It did not configure on many of the test beds. Even on those that were configured, everything did not go smoothly. For example, on the HCL Beantalk 4455 with Geforce2 MX 400, the desktop was configured, by default, at an uncomfortable resolution of 1,600 x 1,200. All the desktop icons were tiny and hardly legible. All attempts to bring the desktop to a lower resolution yielded strange results. On restarting the X server after changing the resolution, the desktop area went outside the monitor's viewable area. Although you could scroll up, or down on the desktop, this is definitely not desirable.

Overall, Lycoris was impressive with its near-perfect Windows desktop look and feel, but lost out on hardware support.



SCORE BOARD

CATEGORY	Windows killers			
	Xandros	Lycoris	Linux 3.0	ELX Linux
Distribution name	22.5	18	15	22.5
Ease of use	2	2	2	2
File system	2.5	0	0	0
Laptop support	15	15	11.25	15
Similarity to Windows	10	10	10	10
Suitability to office use	4	4	4	4
Printing subsystem	2	2	2	2
System administration	1.2	1.2	1	1.8
Internet readiness	4	4	2.75	3.5
Graphical configuration	0.8	0	-0.4	0.8
Features	4	3	2	4
Special features	2	3	3	2
Glaring deficiencies	1.8	2.4	2.4	1.8
Resource utilisation	5.71	1.43	6.67	6.19
Desktop hardware support	2	2	2	4
Economy	67.8	60.6	52	67.4
Overall score				